

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



Unsporting Maya

LUCKNOW Chief Minister Mayawati's decision to demolish the Bhimrao Ambedkar stadium to make way for her dream project, Ambedkar Sthal, has ignited the tempers of sportspersons and local citizens. On the night on July 9, as bulldozers rolled into the stadium to erase it from the city map, sportspersons and coaches along with the stadium staff squatted on the ground in defiance. "We will allow the demolition only over our dead bodies," said Nagendra

Singh, a former weightlifting coach.

The news spread like wild fire and a public interest litigation was filed in the high court the same night resulting in a stay order on the demolition. Ironically, the Rs 72-crore stadium was unveiled in 1997 by Mayawati herself, who was then the chief minister. It boasts of the only Olympic-size swimming pool in the state, apart from having nurtured cricketers like Suresh Raina, R.P. Singh and Piyush Chawla.

IN THE RACE: Mayawati wanted the stadium razed

Mayawati's unsporting activities are not restricted to bulldozing stadiums. In her previous regime, she had announced reservation for the Scheduled Castes in sports teams and hostels. She was later forced to withdraw the order following staunch opposition from the sports community.

But the chief minister is not alone in putting sports on the backburner for personal preferences. While in power, Mulayam Singh Yadav had ordered the demolition of the badminton academy to expand his dream project Lohia Park. It had again taken a court's intervention to save the building.

Sports in Uttar Pradesh is already in a shambles. Most stadiums lack coaches, play grounds are ill-maintained and sportspersons are denied proper equipment and facilities. For Mayawati, this may well turn out to be a race that she may find hard to win.

by Subhash Mishra

Naked News

RAJKOT Journalists, notably the new TV breed, are not the types to let anything come in the way of a good story. Not even a women's clothes. Puja Chauhan, the "harassed" housewife of Rajkot, may have had enough reasons to march through the city streets to protest the alleged barbarities of her in-laws. It now appears that a cartel of lo-



STRIPPED EASE: Chauhan

cal TV reporters persuaded Chauhan to walk clad only in her lingerie, saying that they would broadcast her march only if she stripped to her undergarments. Her near-naked walk-athon grabbed nationwide attention and brought the Union Government and a host of women groups to her help.

But it now seems that she was as much a sinner as sinned against. The police, it is learnt, had already booked a case against her in-laws before she went on her march. Her in-laws are said to have filed a police complaint against her accusing her of harassing and torturing them. They also claim that she drinks and smokes. Her husband Pratapsinh alleges that he was unaware that the 22-year-old had been married twice earlier. Puja rejects all charges just like she rejected most of her clothes.

by Uday Mahurkar

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